



international cricket. We need to test these venues by taking the game to Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, where there is greater crowd involvement and more opportunities and encouragement for stakeholders, including players and guardians. If people see these kinds of events in smaller places, it will generate more interest and help the overall development of the game.

As far as the bigger venues are concerned, the ICC told us that we must have five venues [for the men's event]. So we want to showcase the best ones available, as the world will be watching these matches and we do not want to take any second chances. There are logistical reasons behind it as well. All five venues have very good connectivity via air. The availability of quality hotels is also important. In some smaller cities, the number of five-star hotels is limited, but in the five big cities, accommodation infrastructure is wonderful.

When you have back-to-back events, both international and domestic, logistics often becomes a nightmare. How does the BCCI handle it?

The only issue is that sometimes the weather poses challenges, otherwise, hosting back-to-back events is not a problem. Hosting IPL matches back-to-back for two months has been a big learning experience for us over the last few years. It has groomed and systemised our ecosystem to take on bigger challenges.

Throughout an IPL edition, the BCCI team is on its toes. Sometimes there are problems too. Last year, we had to stall the tournament for two days due to the tension at the border.

Later, after the restart, the pre-monsoon in Kerala and other regions led to weather issues during the later stages. We had to shift some venues to make sure matches were not washed out.

Looking ahead: Right now, there are 30 international-standard stadiums in the country that can host any form of international cricket, says Devajit Saikia. RITU RAJ KONWAR

You talked about the crowded calendar for both players and associations. With so many events, how do you manage things?

Having 30 international-standard venues and stadiums helps. Otherwise, to rotate matches, it would take two to three years with only 10 or 15 venues. With 30 venues, stadiums see more footfalls and remain in use throughout the year. I'm sure more matches in the country will help venues be ready for any kind of event. To keep a stadium ready, a lot of maintenance work has to be done, so frequent matches help in that regard. Otherwise, if a stadium does not host matches for a year or two, it can become a white elephant.